

Ghiglia (Privacy Guarantor): "Civic Education in the Digital Age: For Children and Beyond"

Let us quickly rid ourselves of the illusion that one is "born learned" in the digital realm. Digital civic education is necessary. Taught to the younger generations (but also with a good review for adults), it would allow us to transform Natives into Digital Citizens and help new functional illiterates avoid exclusion in the digital era.

Intervention by Agostino Ghiglia, Member of the Guarantor for the Protection of Personal Data (CyberSecurity360.it, September 18, 2023)

There are various positions expressed by the main players in the sector regarding the so-called "digital natives." In the digital age, it is commonly believed that young people "are born learned," or rather, the idea is widespread that simply being "digital natives" or belonging to Generation Z or Alpha provides young people with additional and "genetic" tools of innate knowledge, almost as if the technological knowledge and digital experiences (when they exist) of their parents could have been transmitted to them.

No one is "born learned" in the digital realm.

We tend too easily—and somewhat superficially—to believe that our children and grandchildren have a greater awareness in using digital technology simply because they "know how to use the devices—not the tools—much better than we do," confusing usage and manual skills with awareness and knowledge of technology and the education necessary to live in the digital age.

Certainly, Alphas or ZGen know how to maneuver a joystick better than a Boomer stuck on the unforgettable video game "Pong" and have superior typing skills compared to an old-school typist, but how much awareness do they have of how much data, especially personal data, they are transmitting (or have already transmitted) to play that game, where it will end up, what it will be used for, how long it will be kept, how many companies will be able to use and manipulate it, turning it into atoms of their business, how many times and in how many ways they will be profiled...

The questions could continue, posing difficulties even for a generative chatbot, but in my opinion, the answer in the vast majority of cases will be negative, as registration and awareness are not "heterozygous twins" that necessarily coexist in the same person.

Making a humble but useful profession of ignorance should not only be the responsibility of the most recent generations but also—I'm not sure if especially, but at least on par—with adults, those who have only studied from paper books and have fingers more trained to press a keyboard rather than scroll on a screen.

The Socratic "I know that I do not know" and not the Obamian "Yes I can" should be the motto of the Digital Age in which we are already fully immersed: it is just a matter of hours... that we spend online. However, we adults are advantaged compared to the latest generations: we have lived a life that is, on average, slower, in a positive sense, more "slow," to use an English term that better conveys the concept, not overwhelmed by superficial hyper-information that diminishes attention after the third line, that limits the expression of thought to 160 characters, that does not appreciate a video that exceeds 30 seconds...

We were not born online, and with those who were born into it but are not yet completely enveloped by it, like Millennials, we have had the opportunity to adequately develop forms of critical thinking and "common sense" in a world that is objectively simpler and less frantically fast.

Such randomness has allowed the majority of us to mature forms of secular free will, a simple distinction between what can and cannot be done, which risks not permeating the new generations: let us think of the crazy and extreme "challenges," the TikTok hedonism that pushes too many to film themselves while speeding in cars, to share personal and intimate photos and videos without any caution or sense of limit, to cyberbully peers for fun (with the aggravating factor that, unlike its ancestor, bullying, this risks having its effects perpetually and indefinitely crystallized)...

New forms of civic education are necessary.

My personal conviction (but going around conferences and debates, I am sure I am in excellent and abundant company) is that the Digital Age, not being a simple and peacefully consequential technological evolution but an epoch-making Cultural Revolution—a new discovery of fire or the discovery of a new fire—urgently requires original forms of Civic Education that instruct on living consciously in the new, more widespread, absorbing, when not totalizing, Netlife. Just as civic education has served over the decades to teach the basic rules of civil coexistence, so digital civic education should instruct on understanding the rudiments of the technologies on which we live—and will increasingly live—much of our waking life (but also of our unconscious life if we use, as a mere and immediate example, sleep monitoring apps...) and the new languages, the new terminology, on which they are based.

The hope, therefore, is that from the very first school cycles, we can introduce—through specific training or updating courses for teachers—the teaching of digital civic education, the opportunities but also the dangers of Netlife, starting from the ABC—the ancient alphabet of Pinocchio—of new technologies and terminologies.

Digital Civic Education: The Importance

In conclusion, digital civic education taught... to the younger generation (but also providing a good review for adults) would allow for the transformation of Natives into Digital Conscious individuals and help new functional illiterates not to be excluded in the digital age, in a society that does not leave anyone behind, that does not increase inequalities and vulnerabilities, both human and non-transhuman: a society in which the human being remains consciously in control of machines without surrendering, without awareness, to the ecstasy of being driven.